DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Can a Saddik Bring Others Into the World to Come?

Derech Hashem 2:3:8

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 3, paragraph 8 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 27 May 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are: five reasons so far

We are in Part 2, Chapter 3, the chapter on personal hashgahah, working through the different reasons the Ramhal gives for why the righteous may suffer and the wicked may prosper (saddik vera lo, rasha vetov lo). The Rabbi began by reviewing the five reasons seen so far: - **Yissurim shel meruk:** suffering that cleanses, from the previous chapter. - **A role in the task force:** different people are given different stations in life, and each must serve Hashem in the role he was given. - **Help or hindrance:** sometimes Hashem helps a person to reach perfection, and sometimes He blocks him a little more, depending on the circumstances. - **Suffering that awakens:** pain sent to stir a person to teshuvah. - **Following one's parents:** the default is that a person's situation follows that of his parents, unless something changes.

On that last point he added a practical remark. People say that you should worry in the years around the age at which your father died. That only applies by default. If you have worked on yourself and made yourself into a better person, it no longer applies.

Paragraph 8: a sixth reason

Paragraph 8 introduces a sixth reason, and the Rabbi warned in advance: "It's going to sound very Christian, this idea coming up, but it's actually not."

The Ramhal has explained that the purpose of creation is to build a gathering of the perfected, those who will enjoy closeness to Hashem in the World to Come. Here he adds that Hashem, in His goodness, decided that some members of that group can bring merit to others. It is not only a person who reaches perfection on his own who enters. Someone who is unable to become perfect in his own right can latch on to another person, be dependent upon him, and enter the gathering through him.

The result is that the only ones who are left outside are people who are themselves corrupt and who also have no connection with anyone more perfect than they are. "You really have to be someone quite terrible not to get a portion." Because of this, many more people will enjoy

the gathering than will be excluded. Those who bring others in will be on the highest level; those who enter by depending on someone else will be on the lowest.

The stadium example

The Rabbi returned to the image he has used throughout the series: the World to Come as a stadium full of fans. You cannot afford a ticket, but you know one of the players, or one of the wealthy people going in, and at the entrance he says, "Let this guy in." You are in. But nobody is going to seat you at the front. "This guy came without paying." You will be somewhere at the back.

Remember that one misvah is already enough to get a person in. This paragraph is about someone who has nothing of his own, but who is connected to someone very great who can lift him up.

Connection to the saddik, and its dangers

The Rabbi explained that this idea is the root of a strong concept in Hasidut: tying oneself to the saddik (hitkashrut). He described the Friday night tish, where followers try to eat from the Rebbe's leftover food, and the Breslov practice of declaring before a misvah that one is binding oneself to Rabbi Nahman, so that one's shaking of the lulav is "as if I'm shaking it with the kavanot of Rabbi Nahman." He was openly critical of some of these practices, which in his view go well beyond what the Ramhal intends.

A participant asked how such a connection works in practice. The Rabbi answered that it cannot be a passing hello. It has to be a real bond: a close talmid, an assistant who drives the Rav around, a strong friendship. It can also come through Torah: after learning enough, a person feels a kind of chemistry with a particular author and book.

He also applied it to Yissakhar and Zevulun. One way to understand the reward of the one who supports Torah is that he facilitated the learning. Here is another approach: by supporting a talmid hakham, he attaches himself to that person, so even if he is not worthy on his own, the connection makes him worthy.

Then came the warning. This is "the whole concept of Jesus: just believe in me and you're fine." The danger is that it takes away individual responsibility. He mentioned people who do nothing all year and rely on going to Uman for Rosh Hashanah. "Maybe it'll get you into the stadium, but you're not going to be anywhere. You're going to be right at the bottom."

Kol Yisrael arevim zeh lazeh

For this to be possible, there must be a real link between people. The Ramhal says that Hashem tied individuals to one another from the start, and this is the meaning of Hazal's statement that all of Israel are responsible for one another. We are connected, not each person a separate island. The Rabbi gave a halachic example: one person can make kiddush on behalf of another, and it is as if the other did it himself.

The Ramhal adds that Hashem's measure of good is always greater than His measure of punishment. We find in Tanakh that many were punished because of one person, as with Akhan, who took from the spoils of Yeriho, after which the whole people suffered at war. If that

applies to the negative, it applies all the more to the positive. The Rabbi recalled what he was told in yeshivah at sixteen: if you push yourself to learn an extra half an hour, maybe you are saving a Jew in Paris from sinning.

Why the saddik suffers

This now gives a new answer to why the righteous suffer. A very great saddik may go through pain that is not for cleansing and not to awaken him, but because so many people are attached to him. He becomes a kapparah for his generation. The Ramhal says the saddik must accept this suffering with love, just as he would accept suffering that was fitting for him. "Think about it, it's so ironic this. Because you've opened yourself up... you're now suffering because of that." By accepting it with love he benefits his generation and is himself raised to one of the highest levels.

The Rabbi linked this to the idea that the death of the righteous atones (as said on the death of Miriam), and to a commentary that explains why one who denigrates the Hakhamim has no share in the World to Come: a person with nothing of his own might have been carried in by a connection to a Hakham, but by despising them he cuts off the only link he had.

He also noted that when we say certain people have no share in the World to Come, it means no share in their own right. Through a connection to someone else they may have a very small portion at the bottom, which is still far better than nothing. Next time: the seventh reason, gilgul.

Summary

- Paragraph 8 gives a sixth reason: a person who cannot reach perfection himself can enter the World to Come through attachment to someone greater, though on the lowest level.
- This is the root of hitkashrut to the saddik, and of one reading of Yissakhar and Zevulun; the connection must be real, not superficial.
- The Rabbi warned that misused, it becomes "just believe in me and you're fine" and erodes personal responsibility.
- It rests on kol Yisrael arevim zeh lazeh: Hashem bound people together, and His good is greater than His punishment.
- A great saddik may suffer as atonement for those attached to him, and must accept it with love.

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